

Pair Pal



Marketing Plan

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Executive summary:

The modern app has given people so much to do, so much to interact with, that it has shoved out of its way the time for the most important connections, those with other people. Pair Pal is an app that we have designed in order to leverage the techniques and systems that these apps use to bring connecting with people back into our lives.

Pair Pal is a creature raising simulator where you and a partner work together to take care of and raise your “Pal”, an interactive character that inhabits this world, that grows based on its connection with its owners. We have used many ideas from game design, such as currencies, earnable decorations, minigames, and timers, that have previously been developed to keep people hooked to games for hours. However, Pair Pal reimagines these tools and directs them towards a mutual, shared goal, building a connection with your partner and raising your Pal.

There are different species of Pals that Pairs can choose to raise, and beyond that, depending on how it is raised, it might even evolve differently, making each pal a unique reflection of its owners. As well, Pals are very smart, being able not only to build complex relations with different owners, emoting how they are feeling, but even being able to go beyond needing an owner and living their own life. Should a Pair let their pal grow to such a stage in their life, they will get the chance to raise another Pal, but their connection and dedication to their old Pal will shine, letting them earn more Love and unlock more for their new Pal.

Pair Pal leverages Firebase, and a simple backend design in order to make sure that there can be real-time updates to your Pal, shared as your partner interacts with your pet. Beyond that, we have implemented many ways for members of a Pair to engage and connect with each other using this system. Players are able to have their Pal hold messages for the partner to see, making sure that the partner gets these handmade messages delivered by the pal you both raised, showing off your hard work. Your Pal may even get too excited to wait to show the message and decide that they want to display it on the Apps Widget on a user's home screen, acting as a reminder that their Pair Partner has sent them a message and that their Pal is waiting for them to come back.

What will your app do?

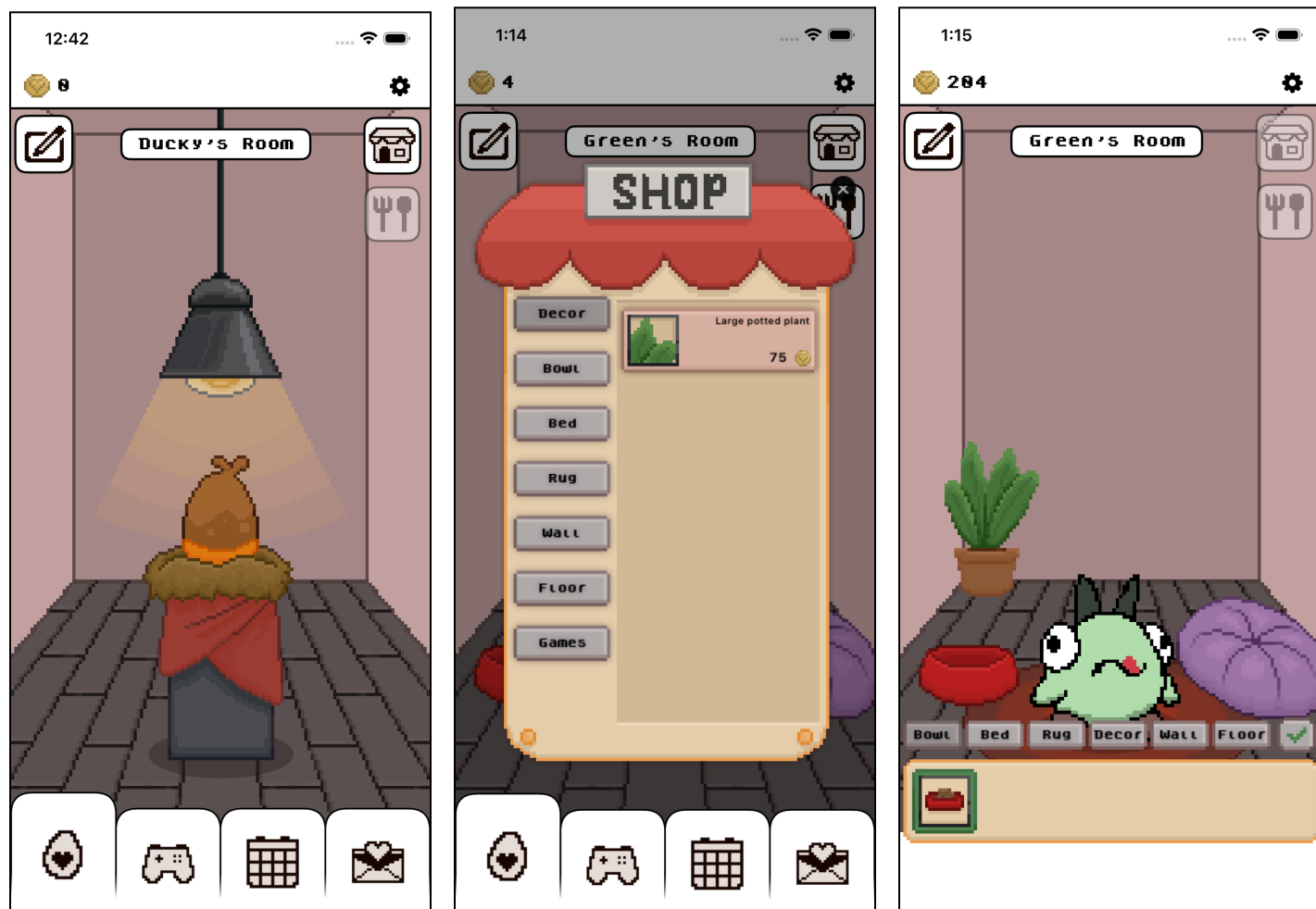
Pair Pal is an app that is intended for use by pairs of users, but can also be used individually. In this app, you can link to a pre-existing pal save, or you can choose a new pal to raise. The pal grows naturally over time where you can pet and feed it. There is a currency called “love” in the app which can be attained by playing mini games with your

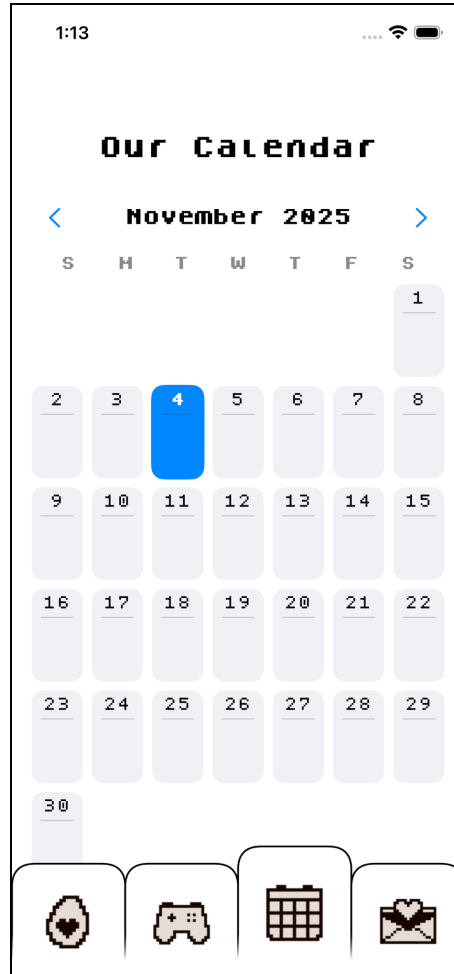
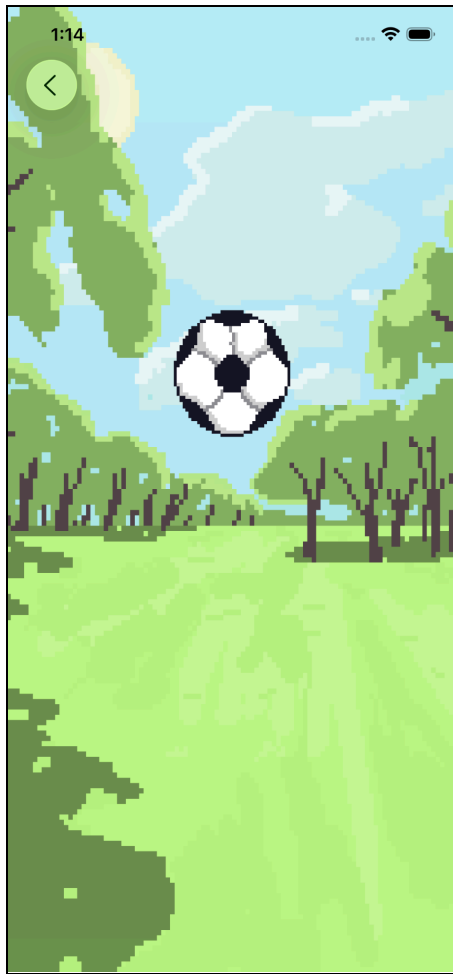
pal, and with “love” you can purchase in the shop for decorations that can be placed in your room. Other features include adding notes to the calendar section, taking pictures, and sending doodles in the app to the other individual also taking care of your pal. Overall, Pair Pal is an app whose goal is to create a cozy and cute digital environment for individuals to bond over a pal, while also having games and customizability to keep the users enjoying the experience.

What does it look like?

Pair Pal focuses on cutesy pixel art as its artistic decision. There are various tabs at the bottom of the screen with pixel icons that redirect you to various views. The “Dogica” font is a pixelated font that stays consistent through the app and adds consistency to the style we want to convey. Additionally, on the main view, there are icons below the top bar that allow you to buy and edit decorations in the room. The top bar contains the “love” currency count and a settings option, which are also small pixel icons. We wanted a cozy feeling to the main room, so we went with a warmer colour scheme there, and in addition to that, the pals change their appearance as they grow up and have animations which make them more endearing.

Below are various screenshots of Pair Pal:





Functionality

The app's central functionality allows you to take care of an adorable pal with a partner, fostering a connection between you and others while also being entertaining at the same time.

Home screen

On the home screen, there are four tabs across the bottom. The main tab, featuring an egg icon, lets you view the pal and its habitat. Inside its habitat are a customary food bowl, your pal, and its bed. You can optionally purchase several things from the store icon on the main screen. You can purchase a large potted plant, three types of food bowls, two colours of beds, a red circular rug, additional paint and flooring, and also additional mini games to play to earn even more currency to spend in the shop. The shop is one of the main reward mechanisms in the game, bringing the user back time and again to get more things for their adorable pal. From the main pal habitat

screen, you can also feed your pal using a button featuring a fork and spoon. If you attempt to feed your pal too soon, a timer will pop up telling you when to come back and feed your pal. In addition, you can edit your pal's room, applying any of the things that you purchased from the store to its room. You can also see how much "love" currency you and your pal have earned together from here as well.

Games Tab

From the games tab, you can select a game and play it. The current games are soccer, where you tap the ball to keep the ball up and gain points for doing so, and jump rope, where you experience a timing-based game and earn points for successfully jumping over the rope. There's a calendar tab at the bottom that allows you to select a date and add a note to it, and a letter menu where you can draw a doodle on a pixel grid with multiple colors, and it's saved to your pal so your friend can see your doodle.

Real Time Connection

The killer feature, or piece of functionality, is that the pal is shared in near real-time between any users who have the pal added to their app. So the doodles are shared between two users when they're connected, as well as the pal's currency, the pal's items, and the pal's other stats, like whether it's been fed and its current growth stage. This data is stored extremely efficiently in the cloud, enabling it to be updated every second. So as soon as your pair buys the pal a cozy area rug, you can see it on your screen as well!

Settings Menu

You can also access a settings menu, where you can save your current pal to the cloud to enable other people to add it to their room, or load a pal from the cloud. All that's necessary to save or load a pal is to put in its name and a password. From here, you can also delete your current save and start a brand new pal. The other menu that should be mentioned is the initial start menu. So when you start a new pal, you can select from one of two eggs and give it a name. Other functionality includes time-based things. You can only feed your pal every so often, and your pal only grows after a certain number of feedings and a certain amount of time.

Pal Animations

Some other functionality includes animations for the pal. The pal can jump up and down, walk left and right, and it has a cute little animation when it stands still, where it bobs up and down. The pal might blink or walk over to its bowl when full of food. Note

that both the intermediate and adult stages of the pal, for both pal types, are fully animated.

Who will be using it?

The main audience that will make up the user base are those in relationships and friendship pairs. The majority of the experiences that are built into the app are designed for use by two people. Throughout the app there are symbols of love, such as hearts, which add to the emphasis on connection. Since the app has a variety of ways of interacting with another user, it works great for long-distance relationships. Beyond romantic partners, the app is also perfect for best friends, siblings, or even long-distance family members who want a low-stress way to stay in touch. Pair Pal emphasizes emotional connection, shared responsibility, and real-time synchronization, which creates a sense of closeness regardless of physical distance.

Age-wise, our app would mainly target teens to young adults who would be drawn in by the colorful, cheerful, and cartoony pixelated aesthetic we have been going for. On the other hand, by using pixelated graphics and deriving inspiration from classics such as the Tamagotchi, we open ourselves to appeal to users of any age. With its room customization features, doodle and picture sharing system, those who heavily value self-expression and creativity would also make up our target demographic.

While Pair Pal is primarily designed for pairs, solo users can also enjoy caring for their own Pal, decorating their space, and collecting items at their own pace. These users would make up the smallest subset of our user base, but would be those seeking companionship or ways to express their creativity in private. These would be the users who use the app more for the game aspect, while using the camera, doodle, or calendar more as a way to journal.

What is the price?

For this app, we want to keep a very low barrier to entry. Since we are relying upon having two people to get the most out of the app, that means we need not just to convince the user that it is worth their time, but also get them to convince someone else as well. So with that in mind, we want the app to be free to play, with in-app options of exclusive decorations and hats for your pal, something like ~\$1.99. Ideally, this should be enough to support our minimal server costs; however, we have other avenues we can explore, too, should we need more funding. This can allow people who are “going against the spirit of the app” to pay money to make up for the difference of not having another person. For example, with one person, you may struggle to feed a pal all the time, though with 2 people, it is trivially easy. For the solo person, they might buy a

“Golden Feeder” for \$4.99 that lets them feed the pal more often. This idea lets us not alienate our core audience of couples, since they will not feel like they need the extra feeding power, but the niche that wants to play the game solo will have an option to do so. The final option we are looking to explore is to allow users to spend money on buying more love in the form of currency bundles if they want to skip the grind and get straight to the shop for their Pal.

How are you going to promote it?

The ideas for promoting our app revolve around focusing on the emotional and social connection between you, your pal, and your partner. It also involves relying on shareability. So, the app will mainly be marketed as a pet-raising simulator and a relationship-building and bonding experience with your partner. To get the app more exposure, we'll first launch it through many different popular social media, such as TikTok, Instagram, and Twitter, which would highlight user's experience with the app, including the pal's evolving, funny interactions with your pal, and other wholesome moments, as well as having short-form videos showing you and your partner's reactions to specific milestones they've reached on the app. These platforms thrive on content that looks cool and interesting, and pairing that with the app's customization options, evolving pals, and special events will offer plenty of shareable moments. Encouraging users to post their own experiences on the app, whether that is their pals or their partner's reactions, will also help get even more exposure to many other places online.

We can also post to online forums like Reddit, where users can share tips and pal progress, encouraging more growth and user-generated content from the app. Since our app is centred around couples, relationship-focused posts could attract users looking to strengthen their bond in a fun way, while also gaining much more exposure for our app. This could include promotional events or in-app rewards for users who sign up through these platforms. In addition to this, we also plan to organize seasonal events to promote them to social media, such as Valentine's or Friendship Week challenges, using the pairing feature on our app. We could also host contests to compete with other couples and offer in-app rewards. All of this would help encourage users to bring their partner into the experience and strengthen their bond as a couple, as well as being able to push the app to other places online for more exposure.

How will you make sure that people continue using your app?

In terms of user retention, the app is designed to rely heavily on pal emotional attachment, social accountability, and the built-in progression in the app. Firstly, the app

focuses on ensuring your pal is well cared for. Pals evolve based on care habits by tending to them, so watching your pal grow fosters a real sense of responsibility and attachment. The “Streak” system also incentivizes users to check back on their pal, where missing two days results in the pal running away. A daily commitment helps ensure that users want to check in every day to avoid losing their pal. We also want to ensure we have regular updates and listen to the feedback we get from people currently using the app. We also want to introduce limited-time events, such as special holiday-themed items, limited pal species, or anniversary content, and constantly add new customization options for pals and the environment, such as new skins, toys, or habitats. Users love getting exclusive content, and won’t want to miss out, and new evolving pals will keep players curious and engaged with the app.

To keep users engaged with the app, we also plan to implement a rewarding progression system where players earn achievements or milestones as they raise their pal. Furthermore, smaller things like daily tasks and the ability to spend currency to unlock cosmetics and things to improve the user experience, like the food dispenser, create consistent motivation to play every day and to keep users engaged. For more long-term progression, the “Pal College”, where pals “graduate” and users would get a currency bonus for the next pal they get, as well as a proper achievement system, provides a way to encourage evolving pals and a sense of accomplishment while providing a set of long-term goals for users to try to complete. Also, having minigames and other things that will encourage couples to interact with their pal will help build their relationship, keep them interested, and give players a reason to return each day. Since the experience within the app is shared between couples, users are led to check up on their pal continuously. Missed days would affect both pair members, so having a mutual understanding and shared responsibility would motivate them to take care of their pal and be rewarded for doing so.

What upgrades could you think of for the future?

In the future, we look to expand PairPal by introducing new features or enhancing the ones we already have in order to retain users and keep new ones coming. The two major places where future expansion would be centred are the shop and the Games tab. We would like to add a vast variety of items in the shop to allow users to customize their room exactly how they want it. Apart from a greater catalog, we also wanted to go even further by possibly having limited-time items that serve as a good goal for users to save up for. These items could either never come back and be exclusive and rare, or they may be thematic seasonal items that can only be purchased during a specific time of the year. The Games tab holds potential in being able to keep users hooked. Adding many new minigames would be a priority for future expansion. This could be supplemented by having a weakly featured minigame that could grant

double coins. Other expansions would be the inclusion of multiplayer games that you and your pair could play together to earn coins. Other features we would look into adding would be the ability to raise multiple pals. Because there are different types of pals, it would be a bit cumbersome to have to make a new account for a new pal, so this feature would let you see other species of pals while not having to start entirely over or have multiple accounts. The pal evolution is another aspect that we could look into updating. By having more stages to a pal's evolution, it draws out the end evolution and would keep players for longer.

How do you keep engaging your current users and draw in new users to your app?

Our app leverages two things incredibly well to keep users engaged: reminders and social pressure. The former most app use in the form of notifications, however we have taken this one step further and also included a widget for the app. What it does is display any recent messages your Pair Partner has sent to you, which will sit on your home screen every time you go by it. This serves as a constant notification that is always passively in people's day-to-day lives as they use their phones. The other thing that will keep users engaged is the social pressure from whoever they are playing with. If they have an interest in growing the Pal, then they are going to remind you to check on it to help it grow. This serves as another reminder, now, though leveraging your relationship with the person as well to get users to come back. The final component of this is that as you and your partner grow your Pal, the two of you will build a shared experience and memories together. This really helps strengthen bonds and connections as you feel like you are both working together for something greater, and taps into the biological human desire to feel like you not only belong to something, but that you are helping make something together.

In order to draw in new users, the primary tactic is aesthetics. Being very cutesy and not like other games, it draws attention to get users to make the first move to install the app. Then the naming and timers are a subtle way to motivate the user to pair up with someone, say a partner, to raise the Pal better. At this point, then the app begins leveraging all the things mentioned prior to keep them engaged and using the app.